



AI and digitalization in relationship management: Impact of adopting AI-embedded CRM system

Sheshadri Chatterjee^a, Ranjan Chaudhuri^{b,*}, Demetris Vrontis^c

^a Indian Institute of Technology Kharagpur, West Bengal, India

^b Department of Marketing, Indian Institute of Management, Ranchi, India

^c School of Business, University of Nicosia, Cyprus

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ABSTRACT

The purpose of this study is to determine the impact of adopting a artificial intelligence-embedded customer relationship management (CRM) system for business-to-business relationship management. After reviewing the literature and considering the theory, a conceptual model was developed. The model was validated using the PLS-SEM technique with 312 responses from 14 firms in the B2B context. The study finds that an AI-embedded CRM system has a significant positive impact towards B2B relationship satisfaction and firm performance. Also, the study highlights that there is a negative impact of the moderator 'technology turbulence' on the relations of 'automated decision making' and 'operational efficiency' with 'B2B relationship satisfaction', whereas there is a positive impact of moderator 'leadership support' on 'B2B relationship satisfaction' and 'firm performance'. There is presently no study on the impact of AI-CRM in the B2B context. Also, the study contributes to the existing literature by incorporating the moderator impact of 'technology turbulence' and 'leadership support' in the context of AI-embedded CRM systems for B2B relationship management.

1. Introduction

Customer relationship management (CRM) is considered a strategic macro process. It aims to ensure building and sustaining a profit-maximization portfolio concerning customer relationship with the firms (Saura, Palos-Sanchez, & Blanco-González, 2019). Many studies have been published on CRM in the B2C context, but explicit research on CRM in the B2B relationship context is still at a rudimentary stage (Irsic, 2017). B2B CRM activities help to analyze the customers' needs by examining the multifarious customer data (Kim, Park, Dubinsky, & Cha, 2012). Some of the huge-sized databases for such B2B relationship management are Matrix Marketing, Ampliz Salesbuddy, Easy Leadz, Leadspace, and so on (Ampliz, 2020). Firms use these B2B databases for accurate and faster targeting opportunities and cross-channel integration, and for effective collaboration with vendors and partners. Analysis of such a huge volume of customer data is difficult for humans. Therefore, appropriately using technology like artificial intelligence (AI) is essential (Josiasen, Assaf, & Cvelbar, 2014; Wang & Feng, 2012). This invites the need to study AI-integrated CRM systems in the B2B context (Harrigan, Soutar, Choudhury, & Lowe, 2015; San-Martina, Jiménez, & Lopez, 2016). AI-integrated CRM systems are associated

with automated decision-making capabilities, which also impact the operational efficiency of the firms in the B2B context, thus influencing satisfaction in the B2B relationship (Alshare & Lane, 2011; Hagen et al., 2020; Huang & Rust, 2018). With the help of AI-CRM, many routine activities can be automated to effectively reduce time compared to those conducted manually. Some of the routine tasks are automated forecasting, auto-processing data inputs, and retrieving and auto-determining the call list and response using NLP (Natural Language Processing) technology. Information transfer is the main ingredient of B2B relationship management (Michaelidou, Siamagka, & Christodoulides, 2011). It has to do with offering and receiving information, thus assisting firms to select and purchase B2B products or services (Agnihotri, Dingus, Hu, & Krush, 2016). There are several benefits that could be derived by using AI-CRM in B2B context. A few such benefits are automated partner selection, lead generation, appropriate segmentation, prioritization without manual intervention, and virtual assistance for vendor selection. An AI-integrated CRM system can help a firm automate its decision-making without human interference (Chatterjee, 2019). This hybrid system (AI-CRM system) can assist firms involved in B2B relationships to perform automated routine tasks and improve customization, segmentation, and prioritization of the acquired

* Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: sheshadri.academic@gmail.com (S. Chatterjee), ranjan.chaudhuri@iimranchi.ac.in (R. Chaudhuri), vrontis.d@unic.ac.cy (D. Vrontis).

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